

REDSTONE ROCKET

The US Army Redstone rocket, created by Wernher von Braun's team at Huntsville, Alabama, was a logical step forward from the V-2. Although designed as a nuclear missile, it became an important early US space booster.

"We gawked at what he showed us as if we were a bunch of sheep seeing a new gate for the first time."

NIKITA KHRUSHCHĚV

ON THE POLITBURO SEEING KOROLĚV'S ROCKET

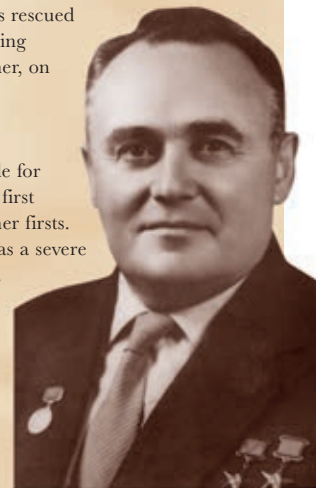
By that time, both the development of long-range missile weaponry and the placing of satellites in Earth orbit had been adopted as priority goals by the United States and the Soviet Union, locked in Cold War confrontation. At stake were military security and the prestige of the competing ideological systems. The Soviets had a long tradition of rocket research to build on. As early as the 1920s the Soviet regime had embraced space exploration as a suitable goal for a society building a new future. Soviet inventors formed

rocket clubs such as MosGIRD – the Moscow Group for Study of Reaction Motion – which sent its first rockets aloft in 1932, one reaching 1,300ft (400m).

Along with other rocket clubs in the Soviet Union, MosGIRD was soon absorbed into the state bureaucracy. The Red Army commander responsible for armaments, Marshal Mikhail Tukhachevsky, was especially interested in rockets as a potential form of long-range artillery. By 1937 most Soviet rocket experts, including Sergei Korolġev, were working for Tukhachevsky, which was unfortunate since

SERGEI PAVLOVICH KOROLĚV

BORN IN UKRAINE, Sergei Korolġev (1906–66) was a recent graduate in aeronautical engineering from Moscow Higher Technical College when he became a founder member of the MosGIRD rocket club in 1931. His talent was recognized by the Soviet state and he led a team at the Rocket Research Institute (RNII) under Marshal Tukhachevsky. In 1938, in the Stalinist purges, Korolġev was arrested, charged with subversion, and sent to the infamous Kolyma mines. Like many others, he was rescued from almost certain death by being recalled to work, still as a prisoner, on aircraft design and then rocket programs. Released in 1944, he directed postwar Soviet rocket development. He was responsible for the first satellite launch and the first manned space flight, among other firsts. His death, of cancer, in 1966 was a severe blow to the Soviet space program.

**SOVIET HERO**

Korolġev died as a hero of the Soviet state which had once sent him to a prison camp. His design genius was allied to remarkable willpower and astuteness that enabled him to operate within the brutal Soviet bureaucracy.